

Oath, Divine Faithfulness, and Christian Truthful Speech

A Biblical and Greek-Theological Study of Oath-Taking, ὁμόσαι, and the Fourfold Oath Framework

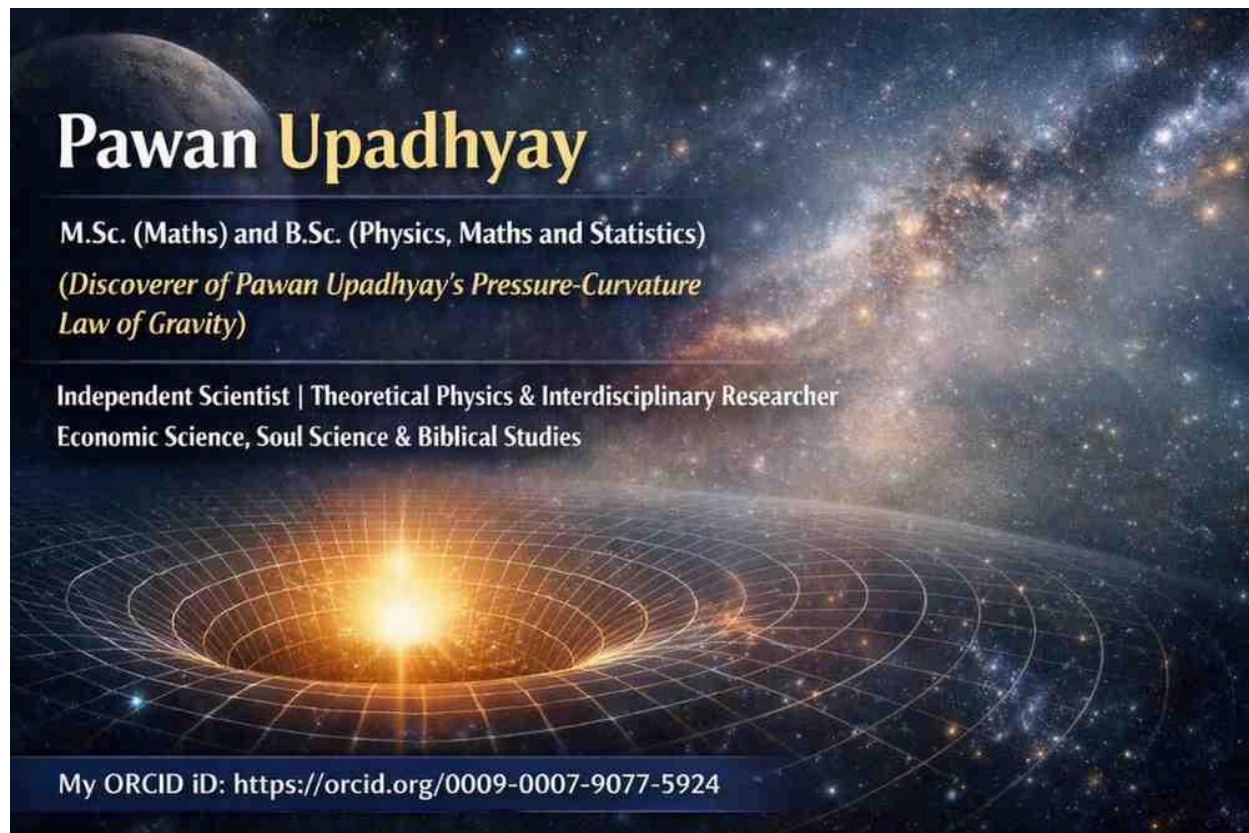
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Abstract

This research paper develops a Christian theological framework concerning **oath-taking, divine faithfulness, human speech, and the command of Jesus Christ: “Do not swear at all.”** The

central biblical texts are Matthew 5:33–37 and James 5:12, with supporting consideration of Hebrews 6:13–18, 2 Corinthians 1:18–20, John 1:1–14, James 4:13–15, Matthew 12:34, Romans 3:23, and relevant Old Testament passages.

Particular attention is given to the Greek expression **μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως** (*mē omosai holōs*) in Matthew 5:34. The word **ὀμόσαι** (*omosai*) is the aorist active infinitive of **ὀμνύω** (*omnyō*), meaning “to swear” or “to take an oath.” The study distinguishes this vocabulary from ordinary speech, represented by **λόγος** (*logos*), and from “yes” and “no,” represented by **ναί** (*naī*) and **οὐ** (*ou*).

The paper proposes that Christian speech should not depend upon oath formulas to establish credibility. Instead, the believer should practice truthful and straightforward speech. The paper further develops a proposed fourfold theological framework: **Divine Oath, Holy Oath, Simple Truthful Speech, and Evil Oath**. It argues that this fourfold model is a theological construction derived from biblical principles rather than an explicit four-category classification found in Scripture.

A central distinction is made between **God's perfect faithfulness** and **human oath-taking**. God may swear by Himself, as described in Hebrews 6:13–18, because His character is perfectly faithful and He possesses no moral or epistemic limitation. Human beings, however, are finite, mutable, fallible, and affected by sin. Therefore, a human oath cannot become divine merely because God's name is invoked.

The paper concludes that the strongest Christian ethical principle is not merely “do not use the word swear,” but rather: **truth should characterize the believer's ordinary speech. Yes should be yes, and no should be no.**

1. Introduction

The subject of oath-taking occupies an important place in biblical ethics.

Throughout Scripture, people make promises, covenants, vows, and oaths. God Himself is described as making promises and, in certain passages, confirming His word with an oath. Yet Jesus Christ gives a striking command in the Sermon on the Mount:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“But I say to you, do not swear at all.”

Jesus then gives the positive alternative:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Let your word be ‘Yes, yes,’ ‘No, no.’”

James later gives a closely related instruction:

μὴ ὀμνύετε

“Do not swear.”

And again the language of yes and no appears.

These passages raise a fundamental Christian question:

Why should the believer's word require an oath at all?

The present research develops a theological answer: Christian speech should be characterized by truthfulness so that the ordinary word itself is trustworthy.

2. Research Question

The central research question is:

What does Jesus mean by “Do not swear at all,” particularly in the Greek expression μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως, and what theological implications does this teaching have for human oath-taking, divine faithfulness, and Christian speech?

Several related questions follow:

1. What does ὀμόσαι mean?
 2. What is its relationship to ὀμνύω?
 3. How does oath-taking differ from ordinary speech?
 4. Why does Jesus move from oath-taking to “yes” and “no”?
 5. How does James 5:12 reinforce Jesus' teaching?
 6. How should God's oath be distinguished from human oaths?
 7. Can a human oath become “divine” by invoking God's name?
 8. How does human sinfulness affect oath-taking?
 9. Can an oath become false, corrupt, or evil?
 10. Can the proposed fourfold classification of oaths provide a useful theological model?
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3. Thesis

This paper proposes the following thesis:

Jesus' command $\mu\eta\ \delta\acute{\omicron}\mu\acute{\omicron}\sigma\alpha\iota\ \delta\lambda\omega\varsigma$ in Matthew 5:34 directly addresses oath-taking and is followed by a positive demand for straightforward speech: “Yes, yes” and “No, no.” Because human beings are finite, fallible, mutable, and affected by sin, a human oath cannot possess the absolute faithfulness of God. Therefore, within a Christian theological framework, the believer should not depend upon oath-taking to establish the truth of speech but should cultivate truthful ordinary speech.

A further theological proposal is:

God's perfect faithfulness may be described conceptually as “Divine Oath,” while human sacred commitments belong to a different category. Human speech cannot become divine merely by invoking God's name.

4. Methodology

This study uses four primary methods:

4.1 Greek lexical analysis

The principal Greek vocabulary of oath-taking and truthful speech is examined.

4.2 Contextual exegesis

Matthew 5:33–37 and James 5:12 are interpreted within their immediate literary contexts.

4.3 Canonical comparison

Other biblical passages concerning God's promises, human limitations, truthfulness, vows, and speech are considered.

4.4 Theological synthesis

The biblical material is organized into a proposed theological framework.

The fourfold classification proposed in this paper is therefore a **theological model**, not a claim that Scripture explicitly presents four formal categories called “Divine Oath,” “Holy Oath,” “Simple Truthful Speech,” and “Evil Oath.”

5. The Greek Word for Oath: ὅρκος

The principal Greek noun for “oath” is:

ὅρκος (*horkos*)

It refers to an:

- oath,
- sworn declaration,
- solemn affirmation.

The noun belongs to the semantic field of sworn speech.

A distinction should therefore be maintained:

ὅρκος = oath

while:

ὀμνύω = to swear

The noun identifies the oath; the verb identifies the action of swearing.

6. The Greek Verb ὀμνύω

The principal Greek verb for oath-taking is:

ὀμνύω (*omnyō*)

Its basic meaning is:

to swear, to take an oath, to swear by.

This verb is particularly important for Matthew 5:34 and James 5:12.

The word is therefore not merely a synonym for “speak.”

Greek possesses other vocabulary for speaking, including:

λέγω (*legō*)

“To say” or “to speak.”

The use of ὀμνύω specifically places Jesus' statement within the semantic field of oath-taking.

7. The Form ὁμόσαι

The exact form appearing in Matthew 5:34 is:

ὁμόσαι (omosaī)

It derives from:

ὀμνύω (omnyō)

Grammatically, ὁμόσαι is:

- aorist,
- active,
- infinitive.

Thus:

ὁμόσαι = to swear / to take an oath.

This is the central Greek word in Jesus' prohibition.

8. μὴ ὁμόσαι

Jesus places μὴ before ὁμόσαι:

μὴ ὁμόσαι

The word μὴ is a negative particle.

Together:

μὴ ὁμόσαι

means:

“not to swear”

and in the force of Jesus' instruction:

“Do not swear.”

The prohibition therefore directly concerns the action expressed by ὀμόσαι.

9. ὅλως — “At All”

Jesus adds:

ὅλως (*holōs*)

The word can mean:

- at all,
- altogether,
- completely.

Therefore:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

can naturally be rendered:

“Do not swear at all.”

The presence of ὅλως is important because it contributes to the strength of the prohibition.

Nevertheless, the precise scope of Jesus' prohibition remains a matter of exegetical discussion. The Greek wording must be interpreted within its historical and literary context.

10. Word-by-Word Analysis of Matthew 5:34

The Greek expression is:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

ἐγώ

“I”

δέ

“but / however”

λέγω

“I say”

ὕμῖν

“to you”

μή

“not”

ὀμόσαι

“to swear / to take an oath”

ὅλως

“at all / altogether”

Therefore:

“But I say to you, do not swear at all.”

The center of the statement is unmistakably:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

11. The Difference Between Swearing and Speaking

The Greek vocabulary allows an important distinction.

Jesus uses:

λέγω

for saying.

He uses:

ὀμνύω

for swearing.

Therefore:

λέγω = say

ὀμνύω = swear

This means Jesus is not commanding His disciples to stop speaking.

He is addressing the use of **oath-taking**.

This distinction becomes decisive when verse 37 is considered.

12. Matthew 5:37: The Alternative to Oath-Taking

Jesus says:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

The significant vocabulary is:

λόγος — word / speech

ναί — yes

οὐ — no

Jesus therefore directs His disciples toward simple speech.

The structure can be summarized:

Do not swear.

Let your word be yes or no.

This suggests that the Christian's ordinary speech should possess sufficient integrity that an oath is unnecessary.

13. The Meaning of λόγος

The Greek word:

λόγος (*logos*)

can mean:

- word,
- speech,
- statement,
- message,
- declaration.

In Matthew 5:37:

ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν

means:

“your word”

or:

“your speech.”

Jesus' concern therefore extends beyond a particular oath formula to the general credibility of the believer's speech.

14. Ναί — “Yes”

The Greek word:

ναί (naí)

means:

yes.

Jesus uses the repetition:

ναὶ ναί

The Christian's affirmation should be straightforward.

When the believer says:

Yes

he should mean:

Yes.

15. Οὐ — “No”

The Greek:

οὐ (ou)

means:

no / not.

Jesus pairs it with **ναί**:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

Thus Christian communication should be clear and truthful.

16. The Ethical Movement in Jesus' Teaching

Matthew 5:34–37 can therefore be understood as a movement:

ὀμόσαι — to swear

toward:

λόγος — word

and:

ναί / οὐ — yes / no.

The movement may be summarized:

Oath-taking → truthful speech

The Christian does not need a sacred formula to make ordinary truth credible.

17. James 5:12

James 5:12 provides an important parallel:

μὴ ὀμνύετε

“Do not swear.”

The verb again comes from:

ὀμνύω

James then gives the same basic yes/no principle:

ναί ναί

and

οὐ οὐ.

The relationship between Matthew 5 and James 5 is therefore striking.

Both passages connect:

oath-taking

with:

simple truthful speech.

18. The Christian Does Not Need an Oath to Tell the Truth

The positive implication of Jesus' command is profound.

The believer should not reason:

“My statement is true because I swore.”

Rather:

“My statement is true because I am speaking truthfully.”

An oath cannot create truth.

An oath can only make a statement solemn or formally binding.

Truth exists independently of the oath formula.

Therefore:

An oath cannot transform falsehood into truth.

19. Human Finiteness

A central part of this theological framework concerns human limitation.

Human beings are:

- finite,
- fallible,
- mutable,
- limited in knowledge,
- limited in power,

- unable to know the future perfectly.

James 4:13–15 is relevant because it warns human beings against speaking with absolute certainty about tomorrow.

Human beings do not control the future.

Consequently, even sincere human commitments remain creaturely commitments.

20. Human Sinfulness

The theological framework also begins with the biblical reality of human sin.

Romans 3:23 teaches that all have sinned.

Jesus teaches that speech is connected with the heart (Matthew 12:34).

Therefore, speech cannot be separated completely from human moral character.

A sinful human being can misuse:

- promises,
- commitments,
- testimony,
- religious language,
- and oaths.

An oath does not remove the possibility of sin.

21. The Human Oath Cannot Become Divine

This leads to one of the central propositions of this study:

A human oath remains a human oath.

If a human being says:

“I swear before God...”

the speaker remains human.

The statement does not become God's statement.

The oath does not acquire divine perfection merely because God's name has been invoked.

Therefore:

Invoking God does not transform human speech into divine speech.

This distinction is essential.

22. Divine Faithfulness

The Bible presents God differently.

God is faithful.

God's promises do not suffer from human ignorance, weakness, or moral corruption.

Hebrews 6:13–18 is especially important because it describes God confirming His promise with an oath.

God swore by Himself because there was no greater authority by whom He could swear.

This is fundamentally different from human oath-taking.

23. Divine Oath as a Theological Concept

The expression:

“Divine Oath”

can therefore be used as a theological concept describing:

- divine faithfulness,
- God's sworn promise,
- God's trustworthy Word,

- the certainty of God's promises.

However, academic precision requires an important qualification:

“Divine Oath” is not a standard formal biblical title for the Trinity or for Jesus Christ.

It is a theological formulation.

Within the framework proposed here, it describes the absolute reliability and faithfulness of God.

24. Christ and God's “Yes”

2 Corinthians 1:18–20 provides an especially important Christological foundation.

Paul emphasizes God's faithfulness and states that God's promises find their:

“Yes” in Christ.

This creates a significant connection with Matthew 5:37.

Matthew:

ναί — yes

Paul:

God's promises are **Yes in Christ.**

Christ is therefore the center and fulfillment of God's promises.

Within this theological framework, Christ can be described as the embodiment of divine faithfulness.

25. Christ as the Divine Oath: A Careful Formulation

If the statement:

“Jesus Christ is the Divine Oath”

is used in theological writing, it should be presented as a proposed theological formulation rather than as a quotation or explicit biblical title.

A careful formulation is:

Christ, as the eternal Word and fulfillment of God's promises, embodies the perfect faithfulness of God. Within this theological framework, Christ may therefore be described analogically as the “Divine Oath.”

This formulation preserves the user's theological insight while maintaining biblical and academic precision.

26. The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit

Christian Trinitarian theology confesses:

One God: Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Therefore, the concept of “one Divine Oath” should not imply:

- three gods,
- three independent divine oaths,
- or three separate divine beings.

Rather, it can refer analogically to:

the one divine faithfulness of the Triune God.

The divine Persons remain distinct, while God is one.

Thus:

One God → one divine truth → one divine faithfulness.

27. Human Oath and Holy Oath

The proposed framework distinguishes human sacred commitment from God's own divine faithfulness.

A **Holy Oath**, within this model, is a human sacred commitment directed toward truth and holiness.

However, even a holy human commitment remains human.

It does not become divine.

The human speaker remains finite and fallible.

Therefore:

Holy human commitment must never be confused with God's absolute faithfulness.

28. Simple Truthful Speech

The third category is best called:

Simple Truthful Speech

rather than "Simple Oath."

This terminology is important because Jesus' words in Matthew 5:37 do not appear to establish a lesser type of oath.

He says:

Yes, yes.

No, no.

The key word is:

λόγος

"word" or "speech."

Thus the Christian alternative to oath-taking is better described as:

simple truthful speech.

29. Why “Simple Oath” Is Less Precise

If “Simple Oath” means a small or uncomplicated oath, it can conflict with Jesus' teaching.

Jesus does not say:

“Take a simpler oath.”

He says:

Do not swear at all.

Then He directs the disciples to ordinary speech.

Therefore:

Oath → no oath → truthful word

is more consistent with the textual sequence than:

Oath → simpler oath.

30. False Oath

A further category is the:

False Oath.

The Greek New Testament has vocabulary associated with false swearing.

One relevant word is:

ἐπιорκέω (*epiorkeō*)

meaning:

to swear falsely / to commit perjury.

This demonstrates that Greek distinguishes ordinary oath-taking from false oath-taking.

31. Evil Oath

The proposed category of:

Evil Oath

goes beyond the narrow lexical meaning of **ὁμόσαι**.

It refers to an oath used for an evil purpose.

Such purposes may include:

- deception,
- false accusation,
- corruption,
- injustice,
- revenge,
- oppression,
- exploitation,
- or harm to innocent persons.

An oath does not become holy merely because sacred language is used.

If a person invokes God while pursuing evil, the religious language does not sanctify the action.

32. Oaths and Injustice

This leads to a broader theological concern:

Oaths can be used as instruments of injustice.

A person may employ solemn religious language to give false claims an appearance of authority.

This can be especially dangerous when an oath is used against an innocent person.

Therefore, the problem is not merely the existence of an oath formula.

The deeper problem is:

falsehood combined with sacred authority.

This can produce serious moral corruption.

33. Oaths and Corruption

When human beings use religious language to justify personal or political wrongdoing, the oath can become an instrument of corruption.

Theological language may be manipulated to support:

- false testimony,
- unjust decisions,
- oppression,
- revenge,
- corruption,
- or destruction.

The Christian response should therefore be a commitment to truth rather than reliance upon solemn formulas.

34. “Oath Is Crime”: An Important Qualification

The statement:

“Oath is crime.”

can be meaningful as a theological or ethical thesis within this framework, but it should not be presented as a universal statement of civil law.

Whether oath-taking constitutes a legal crime depends upon:

- jurisdiction,
- context,
- the type of oath,
- false testimony,
- perjury,
- and applicable law.

Therefore, academically safer wording is:

“Oath-taking can become morally corrupt or legally criminal when it involves falsehood, perjury, deception, or injustice.”

If the theological position being defended is that Christians should not take oaths, that should be argued from Scripture rather than from the claim that every oath is legally a crime.

35. Divine Oath and Human Oath: Fundamental Difference

The proposed theology can therefore distinguish:

Divine	Human
Perfectly faithful	Fallible
Perfect knowledge	Limited knowledge
Unchanging in divine character	Mutable
Holy	Affected by sin
Absolute reliability	Limited reliability
Divine promise	Human commitment

This distinction prevents the human oath from being elevated to the level of God's own faithfulness.

36. The Fourfold Oath Framework

The theological framework developed in this study can be summarized as follows:

I. Divine Oath

God's perfect and faithful sworn promise.

II. Holy Oath

A human sacred commitment directed toward truth and holiness.

III. Simple Truthful Speech

The believer's ordinary:

Yes

and:

No.

IV. Evil Oath

An oath corrupted by falsehood, deception, injustice, corruption, or evil purpose.

Again, these four categories are a **proposed theological framework**, not a formal four-part classification explicitly stated in Scripture.

37. Relationship Between the Four Categories

The proposed relationship may be expressed:

Divine Oath → Holy Truth → Simple Truthful Speech

while:

Human sin + oath-taking → possible false, corrupt, or evil oath

The model therefore distinguishes God's perfect faithfulness from human speech.

38. A More Precise Theological Formula

The entire framework can be expressed in the following proposition:

God's faithfulness is divine and absolute. Human oath-taking is creaturely and limited. A human oath cannot become divine by invoking God's name. Because human beings are finite, mutable, fallible, and affected by sin, oath-taking is vulnerable to falsehood and misuse. Jesus therefore directs His disciples toward straightforward truthful speech: "Let your word be yes, yes; no, no."

39. Does Scripture Explicitly Say "Christ Is the Divine Oath"?

No.

This point should be stated clearly in scholarly work.

Scripture explicitly presents:

- Christ as the Word,
- Christ as the fulfillment of God's promises,
- God's promises as "Yes" in Christ,
- and God as faithful.

But the exact phrase:

"Christ is the Divine Oath"

is a theological formulation.

It can be defended as a theological analogy based on God's promises and Christ's fulfillment of them, but it should not be presented as though it were a direct biblical title.

40. Does Scripture Explicitly Name the Four Categories?

No.

The Bible does not provide a formal fourfold taxonomy called:

1. Divine Oath,

2. Holy Oath,
3. Simple Oath,
4. Evil Oath.

These categories are a theological construction.

Their value lies in organizing biblical concepts into a coherent framework.

For academic credibility, the paper should therefore repeatedly distinguish:

biblical text

from:

theological synthesis.

41. The Strength of the Greek Argument

The Greek word study establishes several important points with considerable clarity.

First:

ὀμόσαι is related to oath-taking.

Second:

μὴ ὀμόσαι expresses “not to swear.”

Third:

ὅλως contributes the sense “at all/altogether.”

Fourth:

Matthew 5:37 immediately redirects attention toward:

λόγος — word

and:

ναί / οὐ — yes / no.

Therefore, the lexical and grammatical evidence strongly supports the observation that Jesus directly addresses oath-taking and emphasizes straightforward speech.

42. The Limits of the Greek Argument

At the same time, lexical analysis cannot prove the entire theological framework.

The word ὁμῶσαι does not by itself prove:

- that every oath is sinful,
- that every oath is a legal crime,
- that every oath becomes false,
- that every human promise is an oath,
- that Christ is literally called “the Divine Oath,”
- or that the Trinity is explicitly called “one Divine Oath.”

Those conclusions require broader theological reasoning.

This distinction is essential for responsible scholarship.

43. Oath, Promise, and Covenant

Another important distinction must be maintained among:

Oath

A sworn declaration.

Promise

A commitment concerning something that will be done or given.

Covenant

A relational agreement or established arrangement.

These concepts overlap in biblical contexts but should not simply be treated as synonyms.

A Christian can make a commitment without necessarily making an oath.

Therefore:

Not every promise is an oath.

And:

Not every commitment is an oath.

This distinction supports the use of “Simple Truthful Speech” as the positive category.

44. The Moral Center: Truth

The ultimate issue is not the sound of a particular word.

It is:

truth.

The Greek word:

ἀλήθεια (*alētheia*)

means:

truth / truthfulness / reality.

Christian speech should correspond to truth.

Therefore the deeper ethical principle is:

The believer's speech should correspond to reality without requiring an oath as an additional guarantee.

45. From Heart to Word

Jesus' teaching elsewhere connects speech with the heart.

Therefore:

Heart → speech → action

forms an important ethical chain.

If the heart is corrupted, solemn language cannot automatically make speech truthful.

An oath does not cure the human heart.

Only truthful character can produce truthful speech.

46. Human Changeability

Human beings also change.

A person may sincerely say:

“I will do this.”

and later discover that circumstances have changed.

This does not automatically mean the person originally intended to deceive.

Therefore, the theological argument should not claim:

Every human oath inevitably becomes false.

A stronger and more defensible formulation is:

Human oath-taking cannot possess God's absolute immutability and certainty because human beings remain finite, fallible, and subject to changing circumstances.

This formulation acknowledges genuine human sincerity while maintaining the distinction between creature and Creator.

47. Human Oath and Absolute Certainty

A human oath cannot guarantee absolute certainty about the future.

James 4:13–15 is relevant here.

Human beings should say:

“If the Lord wills...”

because the future is ultimately beyond human control.

This provides an important theological reason for humility in human speech.

48. The Christian Alternative

Jesus' alternative is remarkably simple:

Yes.

No.

The Christian does not need:

“I swear...”

“I swear before heaven...”

“I swear before God...”

to make every ordinary statement credible.

The goal is a life in which:

the word itself can be trusted.

49. The Central Principle

The central principle of this research can therefore be expressed:

Christian truthfulness should be so genuine that an oath becomes unnecessary as a means of establishing credibility.

This does not mean every Christian will never make a mistake.

It means that intentional truthfulness should characterize Christian speech.

50. Theological Proposition

The research developed here can be summarized in one extended proposition:

The Greek expression **μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως** in Matthew 5:34 identifies Jesus' direct prohibition concerning oath-taking. The central verb **ὀμόσαι**, from **ὀμνύω**, means “to swear” or “to take an oath.” Jesus then contrasts oath-taking with the believer's **λόγος**, or word/speech, requiring **ναὶ ναὶ** and **οὐ οὐ**—yes and no. Because human beings are finite, mutable, fallible, and affected by sin, human oath-taking cannot possess the absolute character of divine faithfulness. God's sworn promise is categorically different because God is perfectly faithful. Christ is the fulfillment and “Yes” of God's promises. Within this theological framework, the expression “Divine Oath” may therefore be used analogically for God's perfect faithfulness, while human sacred commitments remain creaturely. The Christian ethical goal is simple truthful speech: yes should be yes, and no should be no.

51. Conclusion

The Greek word **ὀμόσαι** provides the central linguistic key for understanding Jesus' statement in Matthew 5:34.

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“But I say to you, do not swear at all.”

The word **ὀμόσαι** comes from **ὀμνύω**, “to swear” or “to take an oath.”

Jesus does not prohibit speech itself.

Instead, He directly addresses oath-taking and then provides a positive ethical alternative:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Let your word be ‘Yes, yes,’ ‘No, no.’”

James 5:12 reinforces the same pattern.

The theological significance is substantial.

Human beings are finite, fallible, mutable, and affected by sin. Therefore, human oath-taking cannot possess the absolute character of God's faithfulness.

God's oath is different.

God swears by Himself because there is no greater authority. His promises are completely trustworthy.

The New Testament places those promises in Christ:

God's promises are “Yes” in Christ.

Therefore, within the proposed theological framework, Christ may be described analogically as the embodiment of the **Divine Oath**, understood as the perfect faithfulness of God—not as a formal biblical title.

The fourfold framework proposed in this study is:

1. Divine Oath

God's perfect and faithful promise.

2. Holy Oath

A sacred human commitment directed toward holiness and truth.

3. Simple Truthful Speech

The believer's straightforward “yes” and “no.”

4. Evil Oath

An oath corrupted by falsehood, deception, injustice, corruption, or evil purpose.

The most important refinement is that the third category should preferably be called **Simple Truthful Speech**, because Jesus does not replace a complicated oath with a simpler oath. He moves His disciples toward truthful speech itself.

Thus the ultimate Christian principle is not merely:

“Do not use oath language.”

It is deeper:

“Let your word be truthful.”

The Christian does not need an oath to make truth true.

The believer's word should already be trustworthy.

Therefore:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

And:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Let your yes be yes, and your no be no.”

Selected Biblical Texts for Further Study

- Matthew 5:33–37 — Jesus' teaching on oath-taking
 - James 5:12 — “Do not swear”
 - Hebrews 6:13–18 — God's promise and oath
 - 2 Corinthians 1:18–20 — God's promises are “Yes” in Christ
 - John 1:1–14 — Christ as the eternal Word
 - James 4:13–15 — human limitation concerning the future
 - Matthew 12:34 — speech and the heart
 - Romans 3:23 — universal human sinfulness
 - Numbers 30:2 — vows and obligations
 - Deuteronomy 23:21–23 — vows before God
 - Leviticus 19:12 — false swearing
 - Exodus 20:7 — misuse of God's name
 - Proverbs 12:22 — truthfulness and falsehood
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Greek Vocabulary Summary

Greek	Transliteration	Meaning
ὄρκος	<i>horkos</i>	oath
ὀμνύω	<i>omnyō</i>	to swear / take an oath

ὀμόσαι	<i>omosai</i>	to swear / to take an oath
ὀρκίζω	<i>horkizō</i>	to put under oath / adjure
ἐπιорκέω	<i>epiorkeō</i>	to swear falsely / perjure
ἐπαγγελία	<i>epangelia</i>	promise
λόγος	<i>logos</i>	word / speech
ἀλήθεια	<i>alētheia</i>	truth / truthfulness
ναί	<i>nai</i>	yes
οὐ	<i>ou</i>	no / not
ὅλως	<i>holōs</i>	at all / altogether
μή	<i>mē</i>	not

Final Research Statement

The Christian is called not to make an oath necessary for truth. The believer's ordinary word should be characterized by truthfulness. Human oath-taking remains human and cannot become divine through the invocation of God's name. God's faithfulness is perfect, while human faithfulness is limited. Christ is the fulfillment and “Yes” of God's promises. Therefore, the Christian ethical ideal is simple truthful speech: yes should be yes, and no should be no.

Greek Word Study of “Oath”: ὅρκος, ὀμνύω, and the Christian Call to Truthful Speech

Introduction

The question of an **oath** is important in Christian ethics because Jesus directly addressed oath-taking in the Sermon on the Mount:

“Do not swear at all.” — Matthew 5:34

He then gave a positive alternative:

“Let your word be ‘Yes, yes’ or ‘No, no.’” — Matthew 5:37

The same principle appears in James:

“Above all, my brothers, do not swear.” — James 5:12

To understand these passages carefully, it is useful to examine the Greek vocabulary behind the English word “**oath**.”

The principal Greek words are **ὄρκος** (*horkos*), meaning “oath,” and **ὀμνύω** (*omnyō*), meaning “to swear” or “to take an oath.” Other related words help us distinguish oath-taking from ordinary truthful speech, promises, and false swearing.

This word study does not by itself settle every theological question about whether every form of oath is absolutely prohibited. Greek vocabulary must always be interpreted within its literary, historical, and theological context. Nevertheless, the vocabulary of Matthew 5 and James 5 provides a strong foundation for understanding the Christian emphasis on truthful speech.

1. ὄρκος (*Horkos*) — “Oath”

The Greek noun **ὄρκος** (*horkos*) means:

- oath
- solemn oath
- sworn declaration
- solemn affirmation

An oath is more than an ordinary statement. It is a form of speech in which a person invokes a higher authority, deity, witness, or sacred reality to strengthen the credibility or binding force of what is being said.

The basic concept can therefore be represented as:

ὄρκος = oath / sworn declaration

The distinction between an ordinary statement and an oath is important.

For example:

Ordinary statement:

“I will tell the truth.”

Oath:

“I swear before God that I will tell the truth.”

The second statement introduces an oath formula.

This distinction becomes especially important when reading Jesus' teaching in Matthew 5:33–37.

2. ὀμνύω (*Omnyō*) — “To Swear”

The principal Greek verb associated with oath-taking is ὀμνύω (*omnyō*).

It means:

- to swear
- to take an oath
- to swear by something
- to make a solemn sworn declaration

In Matthew 5, this verb is central to Jesus' teaching.

Matthew 5:34 contains:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

The expression may be translated:

“Do not swear at all.”

The verb comes from ὀμνύω, “to swear.”

Matthew 5:37 then gives the positive alternative:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

Literally, this concerns the believer's **word** being:

“Yes, yes” and “No, no.”

Thus Matthew presents an important contrast:

ὀμνύω → **oath-taking**

versus

λόγος + ναί / οὐ → **straightforward speech**

The ethical movement is therefore from dependence on oath formulas toward integrity of ordinary speech.

3. ὀρκίζω (*Horkizō*) — “To Put Under Oath”

Another related Greek verb is ὀρκίζω (*horkizō*).

It means:

- to put someone under oath
- to adjure
- to require someone to swear
- to solemnly charge someone

This word is related to ὄρκος.

The distinction is useful:

ὄρκος = oath

ὀμνύω = to swear

ὀρκίζω = to put someone under oath or adjure them

These words belong to the same semantic field.

4. ἐπιорκέω (*Epiorkeō*) — False Swearing

The Greek language also contains an important word for **false swearing**:

ἐπιорκέω (*epiorkeō*)

It refers to:

- swearing falsely
- perjury
- violating an oath
- breaking an oath through falsehood

This word is particularly important for Christian ethics because Scripture does not merely discuss the existence of oaths. It also condemns the misuse of sworn speech.

This gives us an important distinction:

ὄρκος describes an oath.

ἐπιорκέω describes false or violated oath-taking.

Therefore, an oath can be considered from at least two different ethical perspectives:

1. the nature of the oath itself;
2. the truthfulness or falsity of the person making it.

This is significant for understanding the relationship between human speech and sin.

5. ἐπαγγελία (*Epangelia*) — “Promise”

Another important Greek word is **ἐπαγγελία** (*epangelia*), meaning:

- promise
- promised blessing
- divine promise

This word should not simply be equated with **ὄρκος**.

An **oath** and a **promise** are related concepts, but they are not identical.

A promise concerns what someone commits to do or give.

An oath is a solemn sworn declaration that can reinforce or establish the seriousness of a statement or commitment.

This distinction becomes particularly important when discussing God's promises.

The New Testament frequently speaks about God's **promises** and God's faithfulness.

For example, Paul writes that the promises of God find their “Yes” in Christ (2 Corinthians 1:20).

This provides an important theological contrast:

Human speech can fail.

God's promises are completely faithful.

6. ἀλήθεια (*Alētheia*) — “Truth”

Christian teaching about oaths cannot be separated from the Greek concept of ἀλήθεια (*alētheia*), meaning:

- truth
- reality
- truthfulness
- sincerity

The ultimate Christian ethical concern is not merely whether a person uses the word “swear.”

The deeper issue is **truthfulness**.

A person who says “yes” but means “no” is not truthful.

Likewise, a person who makes an oath while secretly intending to deceive is not truthful.

Therefore, the Christian ethic of speech reaches beneath the external form of language and addresses the heart.

7. λόγος (*Logos*) — “Word” or “Speech”

Matthew 5:37 uses another significant word:

λόγος (*logos*)

Here it refers to a person's:

- word
- statement

- speech
- declaration

Jesus says that the believer's **λόγος** should be characterized by straightforward affirmation and denial:

ναί ναί — yes, yes

οὐ οὐ — no, no

This is significant.

Jesus does not tell his disciples to replace one oath with another oath.

Instead, he directs them toward trustworthy ordinary speech.

The ideal is:

Say yes when you mean yes.

Say no when you mean no.

The credibility of Christian speech should arise from the character of the speaker rather than from increasingly elaborate oath formulas.

8. Ναί (*Nai*) — “Yes”

The Greek word **ναί** (*nai*) means:

yes

In Matthew 5:37, “yes” is repeated:

ναὶ ναί

The repetition gives emphasis.

Jesus' teaching is fundamentally about correspondence between the person's word and reality.

A Christian's **yes** should genuinely mean yes.

A person's commitment should not require additional religious formulas merely to make it believable.

9. Οὐ (Ou) — “No”

The Greek word οὐ (*ou*) means:

no / not

Matthew 5:37 pairs it with ναί:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

This produces a very simple ethical principle:

Yes should mean yes.

No should mean no.

Christian integrity therefore begins with simple, truthful speech.

10. Matthew 5:33–37 — The Central Passage

Matthew 5:33–37 is the primary New Testament passage for a Greek word study of oath-taking.

Jesus begins with the traditional teaching concerning oaths and then intensifies the ethical requirement.

The key Greek vocabulary includes:

Greek	Transliteration	Meaning
ὄρκος	<i>horkos</i>	oath
ὀμνύω	<i>omnyō</i>	swear, take an oath
ὀρκίζω	<i>horkizō</i>	put under oath, adjure
ἐπιорκέω	<i>epiorkeō</i>	swear falsely, perjure

λόγος	<i>logos</i>	word, speech
ναί	<i>nai</i>	yes
οὐ	<i>ou</i>	no
ἀλήθεια	<i>alētheia</i>	truth, truthfulness
ἐπαγγελία	<i>epangelia</i>	promise

The most important movement in Matthew 5:33–37 is:

oath-taking → truthful speech

Jesus' instruction is therefore not simply a linguistic prohibition. It concerns the moral character of the speaker.

11. James 5:12 Confirms the Principle

James 5:12 is remarkably close to Matthew 5:33–37.

James writes:

μὴ ὀμνύετε

“Do not swear.”

The verb is again derived from **ὀμνύω**.

James then gives the same basic positive pattern:

ναί ναί

and

οὐ οὐ

This lexical connection is important.

Matthew:

ὀμνύω → do not swear → yes/no

James:

ὁμνύω → do not swear → yes/no

The repetition strongly suggests that the Christian community was being taught to cultivate a form of speech that did not depend upon oath-taking for credibility.

12. The Problem of Human Oaths

This vocabulary can also help develop a theological reflection on human limitations.

Human beings are:

- finite
- fallible
- changeable
- vulnerable to temptation
- capable of deception
- unable to know the future perfectly

Therefore, a human oath cannot possess the same character as God's faithfulness.

A human person may sincerely promise something and later fail.

That failure does not necessarily mean the person was intentionally lying when the promise was made. Circumstances may change. Human knowledge is limited. Human strength is limited.

Scripture recognizes this human limitation.

James 4:13–15, for example, warns human beings against speaking with absolute confidence about the future because they do not know what tomorrow will bring.

This gives theological significance to Jesus' emphasis on truthful speech.

The Christian does not need to present himself as possessing divine certainty.

He should simply speak truthfully.

13. Human Oath and Divine Faithfulness

Here an important distinction must be maintained.

The Bible does speak about **God swearing an oath**.

Hebrews 6:13–18 describes God confirming his promise with an oath and emphasizes that God swore by Himself because there was no one greater by whom He could swear.

God's oath therefore cannot simply be placed on the same level as a human oath.

God is not:

- ignorant,
- morally corrupt,
- uncertain,
- changeable in the way human beings are,
- dependent upon another authority.

This creates a theological distinction:

Divine faithfulness is absolute.

Human faithfulness is creaturely and limited.

Consequently, within a theological framework that uses the expression “**Divine Oath**,” the term should be understood carefully. Scripture does not formally give the Trinity the title “the Divine Oath.” Rather, the expression can function as a theological concept for God's absolute faithfulness, sworn promise, and trustworthy Word.

14. Christ and the “Divine Oath”

A particularly important New Testament connection is found in **2 Corinthians 1:18–20**.

Paul connects God's faithfulness with Christ and declares that God's promises find their “Yes” in Him.

This provides a powerful theological pattern:

God's promise → Yes → Christ

Jesus Christ is therefore the center and fulfillment of God's promises.

The Gospel of John provides another important connection by identifying Christ with the **Word** (λόγος).

Thus, within a theological framework, one may describe Christ as the **embodiment of divine faithfulness** and, more specifically, use the phrase “**Divine Oath**” as a theological analogy.

However, it is important not to claim that “Divine Oath” is a formal biblical title for Jesus.

A careful formulation would be:

Christ, as the eternal Word and the fulfillment of God's promises, embodies the perfect faithfulness of God. Within this theological framework, Christ may therefore be described analogically as the “Divine Oath.”

15. The Trinity and One Divine Faithfulness

Christian theology confesses:

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are one God.

They are not three gods.

Therefore, if the expression “**Divine Oath**” is used theologically in relation to the Trinity, it should not mean that the Father is one oath, the Son another oath, and the Spirit a third oath.

Rather, the concept can express the **one divine faithfulness of the one Triune God**.

The distinction between the divine Persons remains essential, while the unity of God's nature and faithfulness is maintained.

Thus:

One God → one divine faithfulness

while:

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit → distinct divine Persons

This is a theological analogy, not a claim that Scripture explicitly calls the Trinity “one Divine Oath.”

16. From Holy Commitment to Human Speech

The distinction between divine faithfulness and human speech also helps develop a fourfold theological framework.

A proposed framework may be expressed as follows:

1. Divine Oath

The absolute faithfulness of God and His sworn promise.

2. Holy Oath

A human sacred commitment understood in relation to God's truth and holiness.

3. Simple Truthful Speech

The ordinary **yes** and **no** of a believer whose speech is truthful.

4. Evil Oath

An oath used for falsehood, deception, injustice, corruption, harm, or sinful purposes.

This fourfold framework should be identified as a **theological model**, rather than presented as a formal four-category classification explicitly stated by the Greek New Testament.

17. Why “Simple Truthful Speech” Is Better Than “Simple Oath”

One linguistic refinement is especially important.

Calling the third category “**Simple Oath**” can create confusion because Matthew 5:37 appears to move away from oath-taking rather than establish a lesser form of oath.

Jesus says:

Yes, yes.

No, no.

Therefore, a more precise theological term is:

Simple Truthful Speech

rather than:

Simple Oath

This terminology better reflects the Greek structure of Matthew 5:37.

The Christian does not need an oath to make truth credible.

The truthfulness of the Christian should make his ordinary word credible.

18. False Oaths and Evil Oaths

The vocabulary surrounding oath-taking also allows us to distinguish several forms of corrupt speech.

A human oath may become:

- false
- deceptive
- empty
- broken
- manipulative
- sinful
- corrupt
- destructive

The Greek concept of **ἐπιορκέω**, false swearing or perjury, is particularly relevant here.

An oath becomes morally dangerous when a person uses solemn language to conceal falsehood rather than reveal truth.

The external seriousness of an oath does not make a false statement true.

A person can say:

“I swear before God”

and still lie.

The formula does not transform falsehood into truth.

This is precisely why Jesus directs attention toward the integrity of ordinary speech.

19. Oaths, Corruption, and Injustice

An oath can also be used as an instrument of injustice.

A person may invoke a sacred authority while pursuing:

- personal revenge,
- political corruption,
- deception,
- oppression,
- false accusation,
- exploitation,
- violence,
- destruction of innocent people.

Such use of religious language is especially serious because it attempts to place human wrongdoing under the appearance of divine authority.

The Christian ethical response is therefore not merely:

“Use better oath formulas.”

It is:

“Speak truthfully.”

The issue is the transformation of speech itself.

20. Oath versus Promise

A further distinction is necessary between an **oath** and a **promise**.

The Greek **ἐπαγγελία** commonly refers to a promise, including divine promise.

The existence of God's promises does not mean that every human promise is an oath.

Likewise, every oath is not necessarily identical to a promise.

The terms belong to related but distinct semantic fields.

This distinction protects Christian theology from an important error:

not every commitment is an oath.

A person can make a truthful commitment without invoking God, heaven, earth, or another sacred witness.

This is consistent with Jesus' emphasis on simple speech.

21. Does the Greek Prove That Every Oath Is a Crime?

No.

A Greek word study cannot establish that every legally or socially recognized oath is necessarily a “crime.”

The word ὄρκος simply means “oath,” and ὀμνύω means “to swear.”

Whether oath-taking is morally permissible in every circumstance is a question of **exegesis, theology, ethics, history, and legal context**, not vocabulary alone.

There has also been scholarly debate about the scope of Jesus' prohibition in Matthew 5:33–37.

Some scholars understand Jesus' words as a comprehensive prohibition of oath-taking. Others argue that Jesus is particularly confronting manipulative, evasive, or elaborate oath practices.

Therefore, a responsible theological argument should say:

The Greek vocabulary strongly establishes that Jesus and James speak directly about oath-taking, while the precise scope of the prohibition remains a matter of interpretation.

22. The Central Christian Principle

The deepest point of the Greek word study is therefore not merely the vocabulary of ὅρκος.

It is the relationship between:

oath

and

truthful speech.

Matthew 5:33–37 and James 5:12 repeatedly bring the believer back to **yes** and **no**.

The Christian should not need increasingly powerful formulas to establish credibility.

His ordinary word should be trustworthy.

The ideal is:

Yes means yes.

No means no.

Truth does not need religious decoration to become true.

23. A Proposed Theological Principle

From the Greek vocabulary and New Testament teaching, the following principle can be proposed:

A human ὅρκος (*horkos*) remains a human oath. It does not become divine merely because a person invokes God. Human beings are finite, mutable, and affected by sin; therefore human oath-taking cannot possess the absolute character of divine faithfulness. In Matthew 5:37 and James 5:12, the Christian alternative is straightforward and truthful speech: ναί should be ναί, and οὐ should be οὐ—yes should be yes and no should be no.

This formulation is stronger than simply saying, “Christians should not swear.”

It identifies the positive ethical goal:

Christian speech must become truthful speech.

Conclusion

The Greek vocabulary of “oath” provides an important foundation for Christian theological reflection.

ὄρκος (*horkos*) means “oath.”

ὀμνύω (*omnyō*) means “to swear.”

ὀρκίζω (*horkizō*) means “to put under oath” or “to adjure.”

ἐπιορκέω (*epiorkeō*) describes false or perjured swearing.

In contrast, **λόγος (*logos*)** refers to word or speech, while **ναί (*naī*)** means “yes,” **οὐ (*ou*)** means “no,” and **ἀλήθεια (*alētheia*)** expresses truth and truthfulness.

The vocabulary of Matthew 5:33–37 and James 5:12 therefore points toward a fundamental Christian ethic:

Do not make an oath necessary for truth.

Let your ordinary word be truthful.

Let yes be yes.

Let no be no.

The perfect standard is found not in human oath-taking but in God's own faithfulness. God's promises find their “Yes” in Christ. Human beings, by contrast, remain finite and fallible.

For this reason, within the proposed theological framework, the Christian ideal can be expressed in a simple movement:

Divine faithfulness → Holy truth → Simple truthful speech.

And when sacred language is used for deception, injustice, corruption, or harm, it becomes the opposite of genuine holiness: an **evil oath**.

The ultimate Christian goal is therefore not merely to avoid a particular word.

It is to become a person whose **word itself is trustworthy**.

Yes should be yes.

No should be no.

Truth should remain truth.

A Deep Greek Word Study of Jesus's Words "Do Not Swear at All" and Greek word "ὀμόσαι (*Omosai*)" study

Jesus's Exact Greek Words

In Matthew 5:34, Jesus says:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

Transliteration:

egō de legō hymin mē omosai holōs

A natural English translation is:

"But I say to you, do not swear at all."

The most important word for this study is:

ὀμόσαι (*omosai*)

This is the Greek word translated **"to swear"** or, in this context, **"to take an oath."**

The significance of Jesus' statement becomes clearer when we examine this single Greek word carefully.

1. The Word ὀμόσαι

The Greek form is:

ὀμόσαι

Transliteration: *omosai*

Basic meaning:

“To swear,” “to take an oath,” or “to swear by.”

The word is not an adjective or noun. It is a **verb form**.

Its lexical form is:

ὀμνύω (*omnyō*)

Meaning:

to swear, to take an oath, to make a solemn sworn declaration

Therefore:

ὀμνύω → ὀμόσαι

The form used in Matthew 5:34 comes from the verb **ὀμνύω**.

2. What Is the Grammatical Form of ὀμόσαι?

ὀμόσαι is an:

Aorist Active Infinitive

This is important because English translations can hide the grammatical structure.

The basic grammatical analysis is:

Feature	Greek
Word	ὀμόσαι

Lexical form	ὀμνύω
Part of speech	Verb
Tense-form	Aorist
Voice	Active
Mood	Infinitive
Meaning	to swear / to take an oath

The infinitive is used after **μὴ**:

μὴ ὀμόσαι

Literally:

“not to swear”

In the context of Jesus' command, this functions as a prohibition.

Therefore the central expression is:

μὴ ὀμόσαι

“Do not swear.”

3. The Root Meaning

The lexical family surrounding **ὀμνύω** is associated with **swearing an oath**.

The important related noun is:

ὄρκος (*horkos*)

Meaning:

oath

The relationship can be represented simply:

ὀμνύω → to swear

ὄρκος → oath

Thus, when Jesus uses **ὀμόσαι**, He is not merely talking about casual vocabulary such as saying “I promise.”

He is addressing the practice of **sworn speech**.

4. ὀμόσαι Is Not Simply “Speak”

This distinction is extremely important.

Jesus does not use the ordinary Greek verb:

λέγω (*legō*)

for the word “swear.”

λέγω means:

to say, speak, tell, declare.

Instead, Jesus uses:

ὀμνύω

which has the specific semantic field of:

swearing / oath-taking.

This means Matthew 5:34 is specifically concerned with the phenomenon of oath-taking.

The contrast becomes even clearer in Matthew 5:37.

Jesus says:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Let your word be yes, yes; no, no.”

Here Jesus uses:

λόγος (*logos*)

for “word” or “speech.”

Therefore there is a significant contrast:

ὀμνύω

to swear

versus

λόγος

word / speech

Jesus moves His disciples toward truthful ordinary speech rather than reliance upon oath-taking.

5. The Meaning of μή

Before **ὀμόσαι** stands:

μή (*mē*)

This is a Greek negative particle commonly used with non-indicative verb forms, including infinitives.

Here:

μή ὀμόσαι

means:

“not to swear”

or in the force of Jesus' instruction:

“Do not swear.”

Therefore we should not study **ὀμόσαι** in isolation.

The complete expression is:

μὴ ὀμόσαι

The negative **μὴ** modifies the oath-taking action represented by **ὀμόσαι**.

6. The Importance of **ὅλως**

Jesus does not merely say:

μὴ ὀμόσαι

He adds:

ὅλως (*holōs*)

The complete expression is:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

ὅλως can mean:

- at all
- altogether
- completely
- in any way

Thus the phrase is commonly translated:

“Do not swear at all.”

The presence of **ὅλως** makes the statement particularly significant for discussions concerning the scope of Jesus' prohibition.

7. Word-by-Word Study of Matthew 5:34

The complete phrase is:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὁμόσαι ὅλως

Let us examine each word.

ἐγὼ — “I”

ἐγὼ (*egō*) means:

I

Jesus personally introduces the teaching.

δὲ — “but”

δὲ (*de*) can function as:

but, however, now

It introduces Jesus' authoritative statement in contrast with what has previously been taught.

λέγω — “say”

λέγω (*legō*) means:

I say / I speak / I declare.

The form λέγω is present active indicative, first-person singular:

“I say.”

ὑμῖν — “to you”

ὑμῖν (*hymín*) means:

to you

It is dative plural.

Jesus is addressing His disciples/hearers.

μὴ — “not”

μὴ (*mē*) is the negative particle.

It introduces the prohibition:

“not...”

ὀμόσαι — “to swear”

This is the central word.

ὀμόσαι (*omosaī*)

comes from:

ὀμνύω (*omnyō*)

Meaning:

to swear / to take an oath

ὅλως — “at all”

ὅλως (*holōs*)

means:

at all / altogether.

Therefore:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

means:

“Do not swear at all.”

8. The Most Important Observation

Jesus does not say:

“Do not lie.”

Although the Bible certainly condemns lying, that is not the specific wording here.

He says:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

He addresses **swearing**.

This distinction matters.

The command is not merely:

“Do not make false oaths.”

The Greek wording directly contains:

μὴ ὀμόσαι

“Do not swear.”

The additional word:

ὅλως

“at all”

makes the passage particularly important for those who understand Jesus to be giving a comprehensive prohibition of oath-taking.

At the same time, the precise scope of the prohibition has been debated by biblical scholars. The Greek wording must therefore be considered together with the surrounding context, Jewish oath practices, the Old Testament, and other New Testament passages.

9. Jesus' Positive Alternative: Yes and No

The meaning of ὁμόσαι becomes even clearer when we continue to Matthew 5:37.

Jesus says:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

The words include:

λόγος

word / speech

ναί

yes

οὐ

no

The basic ethical principle is:

Let your word be yes, yes; no, no.

This is extraordinary because Jesus does not replace one oath with another oath.

He points toward ordinary truthful speech.

10. Oath-Taking versus Truthful Speech

The Greek vocabulary therefore creates an important conceptual contrast:

Oath-taking

ὀμνύω

“To swear.”

Truthful speech

λόγος

“Word/speech.”

Affirmation

ναί

“Yes.”

Negation

οὐ

“No.”

The Christian ideal can therefore be expressed:

Do not make an oath necessary to establish the truthfulness of your word. Let your word itself be truthful.

11. ὁμόσαι and the Human Problem of Sin

This word study also has theological significance.

Human beings are not perfectly faithful.

Scripture describes humanity as sinful and fallible. Consequently, a human being can make a solemn oath and still fail to fulfill it.

There are many possible reasons:

- intentional deception,
- changing circumstances,
- ignorance,
- weakness,
- temptation,
- forgetfulness,
- inability to fulfill the commitment,
- or deliberate falsehood.

Therefore, an oath does not transform a human being into a perfectly faithful person.

An oath can make a statement solemn.

It cannot make a sinful human being divine.

12. An Oath Does Not Become Divine

This provides an important theological principle.

A human being can say:

“I swear before God.”

But the addition of God's name does not transform the human speaker's oath into God's own divine faithfulness.

The speaker remains human.

The oath remains a human oath.

This distinction is especially important when comparing human oath-taking with God's own sworn promise.

13. Divine Faithfulness Is Different

The New Testament can speak of God making an oath.

Hebrews 6:13–18 is particularly important because it describes God confirming His promise with an oath.

God's oath is not comparable to human oath-taking in every respect.

God is perfectly faithful.

Human beings are not.

God possesses perfect knowledge.

Human beings do not.

God's faithfulness is absolute.

Human faithfulness is limited.

Therefore:

God's sworn promise

cannot simply be equated with

a human oath.

14. The “Divine Oath” Concept

This distinction provides a basis for a theological concept that may be called:

“Divine Oath”

This should be identified carefully.

“Divine Oath” is not a standard formal biblical title for the Trinity or for Christ.

Rather, it can be used as a **theological formulation** describing God's absolute faithfulness and His sworn promise.

The New Testament connects God's promises particularly strongly with Christ.

Paul writes that God's promises find their **“Yes” in Christ** (2 Corinthians 1:20).

This creates a profound theological connection:

God's promise → Yes → Christ

Within such a framework, Christ can be described analogically as the embodiment and fulfillment of divine faithfulness.

15. Christ and “Yes”

Matthew 5:37 says:

vai vai

“Yes, yes.”

Paul's statement in 2 Corinthians 1:20 gives the Christian theology of divine "Yes" a Christological center:

God's promises are "Yes" in Christ.

Therefore, there is an interesting theological contrast:

Human speech

"Let your yes be yes."

Divine promise

God's promises are "Yes" in Christ.

The human Christian is called to reflect, imperfectly, the faithfulness that is perfectly present in God.

16. The Trinity and One Divine Faithfulness

If the expression "**Divine Oath**" is used in Trinitarian theology, it should not imply three gods or three separate divine oaths.

Christian doctrine confesses:

One God — Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Therefore, "one Divine Oath" can function as an analogy for:

the one divine faithfulness of the Triune God.

The Father is not one god.

The Son is not another god.

The Holy Spirit is not a third god.

The three divine Persons share the one divine nature.

Therefore the theological idea should be expressed as:

One God, one divine faithfulness, one divine truth.

This is a theological analogy, not a claim that the Greek New Testament explicitly calls the Trinity “one oath.”

17. False Swearing: ἑπιорκέω

The Greek New Testament also contains the verb:

ἑπιорκέω (*epiorkeō*)

meaning:

to swear falsely / to commit perjury.

This provides an important contrast.

ὀμνύω

to swear

ἑπιорκέω

to swear falsely

Therefore, Greek vocabulary distinguishes the act of oath-taking from the sinful misuse of an oath.

A person may take an oath sincerely and fail later.

But deliberate false swearing is a more specific moral problem.

18. Evil Oath

This distinction can be incorporated into a theological framework of **Evil Oath**.

An “evil oath” would not mean simply an oath that happens to contain the word “swear.”

It would refer to an oath employed for an evil purpose, such as:

- deception,
- false accusation,
- injustice,
- corruption,
- oppression,
- revenge,
- or harm to innocent people.

The Greek word **ἐπιρκέω** is especially relevant to false swearing, while the broader theological category of “evil oath” requires additional ethical analysis beyond the lexical meaning of ὁμόσαι.

19. The Fourfold Framework

The Greek word study can therefore support—but does not itself prove—the following proposed theological framework:

Category	Meaning
Divine Oath	God's perfect and faithful sworn promise
Holy Oath	Sacred human commitment understood in relation to divine truth
Simple Truthful Speech	Ordinary truthful “yes” and “no”
Evil Oath	Oath used falsely, corruptly, unjustly, or harmfully

The terminology “**Simple Truthful Speech**” is preferable to “Simple Oath” because Jesus' **ναί / οὐ** instruction appears to direct disciples toward straightforward speech rather than another category of oath.

20. What ὁμόσαι Does—and Does Not—Prove

A responsible Greek word study must recognize its limits.

The word ὁμόσαι establishes that Jesus is talking about:

swearing / oath-taking.

The phrase:

μὴ ὁμόσαι ὅλως

can naturally be translated:

“Do not swear at all.”

However, the word itself does not prove every part of a complete theological system.

For example, Greek vocabulary alone cannot establish:

- that every oath is legally a crime;
- that every oath is necessarily false;
- that every human promise is an oath;
- that the Trinity is formally called “the Divine Oath”;
- or that every Christian tradition must interpret Matthew 5:34 identically.

Those conclusions require broader biblical and theological argument.

This distinction makes the argument stronger, not weaker.

21. The Deepest Meaning of Jesus' Teaching

The ultimate point of Matthew 5:34–37 is not merely vocabulary.

It concerns **integrity**.

Jesus wants the relationship between:

heart → word → truth

to become direct.

A person should not need an oath to persuade others that his statement is true.

The believer's character should make his word trustworthy.

Thus:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

is followed by:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Yes, yes; no, no.”

The movement is:

from oath-taking

to truthful speech.

22. A Theological Summary

The Greek word **ὀμόσαι** is therefore highly significant.

It comes from **ὀμνύω**, the principal verb for swearing or taking an oath.

Its grammatical form is an **aorist active infinitive**, functioning with **μὴ** in Jesus' prohibition.

The complete phrase:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

is literally concerned with:

not swearing at all.

Jesus then provides the positive alternative:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Let your word be yes, yes; no, no.”

The theological principle can therefore be summarized:

A Christian's word should not require an oath to become trustworthy. The believer is called to truthful speech in which “yes” genuinely means yes and “no” genuinely means no.

Conclusion

The single Greek word ὀμόσαι opens a much larger window into Jesus' teaching.

ὀμόσαι means “to swear” or “to take an oath.”

It comes from ὀμνύω, the Greek verb associated with oath-taking.

Jesus places it within the strong expression:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

He then directs His disciples toward:

ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Yes, yes; no, no.”

The contrast is therefore profound.

The Christian life should not be built upon increasingly solemn formulas designed to make human speech believable.

It should be built upon **truth**.

Human beings remain finite, fallible, and capable of sin. Their oaths therefore cannot possess the absolute faithfulness of God.

God's faithfulness is perfect.

Christ is the fulfillment of God's promises.

And the Christian is called to reflect that divine truthfulness through ordinary human speech.

Therefore the central ethical principle may be stated simply:

Do not make an oath necessary for truth.

Let your word be truthful.

Let your yes be yes.

Let your no be no.

And in the language of Matthew 5:34:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως: The Greek Meaning of Jesus’ Command “Do Not Swear at All”

A Deep Word-by-Word Study of Matthew 5:34

Jesus’ teaching about oaths is one of the most important statements in the Sermon on the Mount concerning human speech, truth, promises, and religious language.

In Matthew 5:34, Jesus says:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

A literal rendering is:

“But I say to you, do not swear at all.”

The central Greek expression is:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

The most important word in this expression is:

ὀμόσαι (*omosai*)

What exactly does **ὀμόσαι** mean? Why did Jesus use this particular Greek verb rather than an ordinary word for speaking? What does the surrounding Greek grammar tell us? And how does this command relate to Jesus' following statement:

“Let your word be ‘Yes, yes’ and ‘No, no’” (Matthew 5:37)?

This study examines these questions word by word.

1. The Complete Greek Sentence

Matthew 5:34 begins:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

Let's divide the sentence into its individual Greek words:

Greek	Transliteration	Basic meaning
ἐγὼ	<i>egō</i>	I
δὲ	<i>de</i>	but / however
λέγω	<i>legō</i>	say
ὕμῖν	<i>hymin</i>	to you
μὴ	<i>mē</i>	not
ὀμόσαι	<i>omosai</i>	to swear / to take an oath
ὅλως	<i>holōs</i>	at all / altogether

The sentence can therefore be understood structurally as:

I — but — say — to you — not — to swear — at all.

The central command is:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

2. ἐγώ — “I”

The first word is:

ἐγώ (egō)

Meaning:

“I.”

Jesus begins with His own authoritative declaration:

“I say to you...”

This expression is characteristic of Jesus' teaching in the Sermon on the Mount.

The significance is not merely that Jesus is giving an opinion.

He presents His teaching with personal authority:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν

“But I say to you.”

The command concerning oath-taking therefore comes directly from Jesus' teaching.

3. δέ — “But”

The next word is:

δέ (de)

It can mean:

- but
- however

- now
- and

In this context, it introduces Jesus' authoritative statement in relation to the teaching immediately preceding it.

Jesus refers to what His hearers have heard concerning oaths and then gives His own instruction.

The important phrase is:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν

“But I say to you...”

4. λέγω — “I Say”

The word:

λέγω (*legō*)

means:

to say, to speak, to tell, to declare.

Here the form **λέγω** means:

“I say.”

This word is important because Jesus uses **λέγω** for speaking, while He uses another verb—**ὀμνύω**—for swearing.

This distinction becomes important later.

λέγω

to say / speak

ὀμνύω

to swear / take an oath

Jesus is therefore distinguishing ordinary speech from oath-taking.

5. ὑμῖν — “To You”

The word:

ὑμῖν (*hymín*)

means:

“to you.”

It is the dative plural form of the second-person pronoun.

Jesus is addressing His hearers:

“I say to you...”

The command is therefore presented as instruction for the community of Jesus' disciples.

6. μή — “Not”

The next word is:

μή (*mē*)

Meaning:

“not.”

It is the Greek negative particle commonly used with non-indicative forms such as the infinitive.

Here it stands immediately before **ὁμόσαι**:

μή ὁμόσαι

Literally:

“not to swear.”

In context, it expresses the prohibition:

“Do not swear.”

7. The Central Word: ὁμόσαι

Now we come to the most important word:

ὁμόσαι

Transliteration: *omosai*

Its basic meaning is:

to swear

or:

to take an oath

The lexical form is:

ὁμνύω (*omnyō*)

This is the principal Greek verb associated with swearing or taking an oath.

Therefore:

ὁμνύω → ὁμόσαι

The form used in Matthew 5:34 is derived from the verb ὁμνύω.

8. What Does ὁμόσαι Actually Mean?

The simplest answer is:

ὁμόσαι means “to swear” or “to take an oath.”

It does not simply mean:

- to speak,
- to talk,
- to promise,
- or to lie.

Those concepts have their own vocabulary.

ὀμόσαι specifically belongs to the semantic field of **oath-taking**.

This is an important observation for interpreting Jesus' command.

Jesus does not use a general verb meaning:

“Do not speak.”

He uses the specific verb:

ὀμόσαι

“to swear / take an oath.”

Therefore, the immediate subject of the prohibition is oath-taking.

9. The Grammar of ὀμόσαι

The form **ὀμόσαι** is grammatically:

Aorist Active Infinitive

Its features are:

- **Lexical form:** ὀμνύω
- **Form:** ὀμόσαι
- **Tense-form:** aorist
- **Voice:** active
- **Mood:** infinitive

The infinitive is governed by the negative:

μὴ ὀμόσαι

This produces the sense:

“not to swear”

or, in the context of Jesus' command:

“do not swear.”

The important point is that ὀμόσαι identifies an action: **the action of swearing**.

10. ὅλως — “At All”

Jesus does not stop at:

μὴ ὀμόσαι

He adds:

ὅλως (*holōs*)

This word can mean:

- at all
- altogether
- completely
- in any way

Therefore:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

can naturally be translated:

“Do not swear at all.”

This is one reason Matthew 5:34 has generated significant discussion concerning the scope of Jesus' teaching.

Does Jesus prohibit every conceivable form of oath-taking? Or is He confronting particular forms of oath-taking and the manipulative use of oath formulas?

Christians and biblical scholars have interpreted the passage differently.

But whatever position one takes on the larger question, the Greek wording itself clearly places **oath-taking** at the center of Jesus' statement.

11. ὁμόσαι and ὅρκος

The verb ὁμόσαι is closely related to another important Greek word:

ὅρκος (*horkos*)

Meaning:

“oath.”

The relationship is straightforward:

ὀμνύω — to swear

ὅρκος — oath

Thus the Greek language distinguishes between the **action of swearing** and the **oath itself**.

This helps us understand that Matthew 5:34 is not merely about the use of a particular English expression such as:

“I swear.”

The underlying subject is the broader practice of **sworn speech**.

12. ὁμόσαι Is Different from λέγω

One of the most useful observations in the passage is the difference between:

λέγω

and

ὁμόσαι

λέγω means:

to say / speak.

ὀμνύω means:

to swear / take an oath.

Jesus first says:

ἐγὼ ... λέγω

“I say...”

and then prohibits:

ὀμόσαι

“to swear.”

This gives us a linguistic distinction:

Saying

λέγω

Swearing

ὀμνύω

The Christian is not prohibited from speaking.

Rather, Jesus' statement specifically addresses oath-taking.

13. Matthew 5:37 Explains the Positive Alternative

The meaning of Matthew 5:34 becomes even clearer when we continue to verse 37.

Jesus says:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐὶ οὐὶ

A natural translation is:

“Let your word be ‘Yes, yes,’ ‘No, no.’”

Three Greek words are especially important:

λόγος

word / speech

ναί

yes

οὐ

no

Jesus therefore gives a positive alternative to oath-taking:

truthful and straightforward speech.

14. λόγος — “Your Word”

The word:

λόγος (*logos*)

can mean:

- word
- speech
- statement
- message
- declaration

In Matthew 5:37, Jesus says:

ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν

“your word”

The believer's ordinary speech should possess integrity.

The person should not need an oath to make his statement credible.

15. **vai** — “Yes”

The word:

vai (nai)

means:

“yes.”

Jesus says:

vai vai

“yes, yes.”

The repetition emphasizes the straightforward character of the affirmation.

When a Christian says:

Yes

his yes should genuinely mean yes.

16. **ou** — “No”

The word:

ou (ou)

means:

“no” / “not.”

Jesus pairs it with **vai**:

vai vai, ou ou

“Yes, yes; no, no.”

The Christian's speech should be clear rather than deceptive or manipulative.

17. Jesus' Complete Ethical Movement

When Matthew 5:34 and Matthew 5:37 are read together, we see a remarkable movement:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

Do not swear at all.

Then:

ἔστω ... ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

Let your word be yes, yes; no, no.

The movement can be summarized:

Oath-taking → truthful speech

Sworn declaration → ordinary word

Religious formula → truthful yes and no

This is at the heart of Jesus' teaching.

18. Jesus Is Not Teaching “Do Not Speak”

This distinction must be made clearly.

Jesus does not teach:

“Do not speak.”

The New Testament contains extensive teaching concerning truthful speech.

Jesus' command concerns:

ὀμόσαι

to swear / take an oath.

His alternative is not silence.

His alternative is:

λόγος

truthful word or speech.

Therefore, Christian obedience does not mean refusing to communicate.

It means communicating truthfully without making an oath necessary for credibility.

19. Oath and Truth Are Not the Same Thing

An oath does not create truth.

A statement is not made true merely because someone says:

“I swear.”

Nor does invoking God automatically make a human statement divine.

The words of an oath remain the words of the human speaker.

Therefore:

An oath cannot transform human speech into divine truth.

This distinction becomes important for a theological understanding of human limitations.

20. Human Finiteness and Oath-Taking

Human beings are finite.

They do not possess perfect knowledge.

They do not know everything that will happen tomorrow.

They can make mistakes.

They can misunderstand circumstances.

They can change.

They can be tempted.

They can sin.

Therefore, even when a person makes an oath sincerely, the human speaker remains a fallible creature.

An oath can make a commitment solemn.

It cannot give a human being divine attributes.

21. Human Oath Is Not Divine Oath

This leads to an important theological distinction.

A human oath is:

human speech solemnly sworn.

God's faithfulness is:

divine and perfect.

The two should not be confused.

When a human says:

“I swear before God...”

the human speaker does not become God.

The oath does not become divine merely because God's name is invoked.

This can be expressed as:

Human oath remains human oath.

It does not become divine simply through religious language.

22. God's Oath Is a Different Theological Category

Scripture itself speaks about God swearing an oath.

Hebrews 6:13–18 is especially important. It describes God confirming His promise with an oath.

But God's oath must not be treated as though God were merely another human being.

God's faithfulness is perfect.

Human faithfulness is limited.

God knows the future.

Human beings do not.

God cannot be reduced to the same category as a sinful human oath-taker.

Therefore:

Divine faithfulness and human oath-taking must be distinguished.

23. God's Promise and Christ

The New Testament gives another important theological connection in 2 Corinthians 1:18–20.

Paul connects God's faithfulness with Christ and declares that God's promises find their **Yes** in Him.

This provides a powerful theological pattern:

God's promise → Yes → Christ

Christ is therefore the center and fulfillment of God's promises.

Within a theological framework, Christ may be described as the embodiment of God's perfect faithfulness.

If the phrase “**Divine Oath**” is used, it should be explained as a theological formulation or analogy rather than presented as a formal biblical title for Christ.

24. The One Divine Faithfulness

Christian theology confesses one God:

Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Therefore, if one uses the expression “**one Divine Oath**,” it should not mean three separate oaths or three gods.

It can instead be used as an analogy for:

the one divine truth and faithfulness of the Triune God.

The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit remain distinct Persons, while God is one.

Thus:

One God → one divine faithfulness.

This is a theological formulation, not an explicit biblical title.

25. False Swearing

The Greek New Testament also contains vocabulary specifically associated with false swearing.

One important related verb is:

ἐπιорκέω (*epiorkeō*)

It means:

to swear falsely / to commit perjury.

This is different from **ὀμόσαι**.

ὀμόσαι

to swear

ἑπιορκέω

to swear falsely

This distinction is essential.

The word ὁμόσαι itself does not mean “to lie.”

It means:

to swear.

Falsehood enters when the oath is made falsely or violated.

26. Can a Human Oath Become Evil?

From a theological and ethical perspective, oath-taking can be used for sinful purposes.

An oath may be associated with:

- deception,
- false testimony,
- corruption,
- injustice,
- manipulation,
- oppression,
- revenge,
- or harm.

A solemn religious formula does not make an evil purpose holy.

If a person uses God's name to support deception or injustice, the religious language itself becomes part of the moral problem.

This is why Jesus' teaching about truthful speech is so significant.

27. The Danger of Religious Language

One of the deepest lessons in Matthew 5 is that religious language cannot substitute for character.

A person can say:

“I swear by God.”

But the statement can still be false.

A person can invoke:

- heaven,
- earth,
- Jerusalem,
- God,
- sacred objects,
- or religious authority,

and still possess an untruthful heart.

Jesus therefore moves the discussion from external formulas to internal integrity.

The question becomes:

Can your ordinary word be trusted?

28. “Yes” and “No” as the Christian Standard

Matthew 5:37 provides a remarkably simple standard:

Yes should be yes.

No should be no.

This does not mean that Christians are incapable of making mistakes.

Rather, it means Christian speech should be characterized by integrity.

The believer should not intentionally create uncertainty through deceptive language.

Nor should the believer need an oath merely to make people believe him.

The goal is:

truthful speech from a truthful heart.

29. The Relationship Between Sin and Speech

The Bible repeatedly connects speech with the moral condition of the person.

Jesus teaches elsewhere that speech comes from the heart.

Therefore, the problem of oath-taking cannot be understood merely as a grammatical problem.

It is ultimately a problem of:

truthfulness, integrity, and the human heart.

If the heart is corrupt, even an oath can become corrupt.

If the heart is truthful, ordinary speech can communicate truth without an oath.

This is why Jesus directs attention toward the character of the speaker.

30. A Proposed Fourfold Framework

The Greek study can contribute to a theological framework consisting of four categories.

These categories should be understood as a **proposed theological model**, not as four categories explicitly named by the Greek New Testament.

1. Divine Oath

The perfect faithfulness and sworn promise of God.

2. Holy Oath

A sacred human commitment understood in relation to divine truth and holiness.

3. Simple Truthful Speech

Ordinary human speech characterized by:

ναί — yes

and

οὐ — no

4. Evil Oath

An oath associated with falsehood, deception, corruption, injustice, or other sinful purposes.

This framework becomes especially meaningful when Jesus' command is placed at the center:

μὴ ὁμόσαι ὅλως

31. Why “Simple Truthful Speech” Is More Precise

The expression “**Simple Oath**” can create a theological problem.

Matthew 5:37 does not say:

“Take a simpler oath.”

Jesus says:

Let your word be yes, yes; no, no.

The key noun is:

λόγος

“word” or “speech.”

Therefore, “**Simple Truthful Speech**” is a more accurate description of Jesus' positive alternative.

The movement is not:

complicated oath → simple oath.

Rather, it is:

oath-taking → straightforward speech.

32. Does ὁμόσαι Prove That Every Oath Is Sinful?

A Greek word study by itself cannot prove that every oath in every historical, legal, or social circumstance is sinful.

This conclusion requires broader biblical interpretation.

The word ὁμόσαι means:

“to swear.”

The phrase:

μὴ ὁμόσαι ὅλως

means:

“Do not swear at all.”

That is strong language.

Nevertheless, scholars have debated whether Jesus intended an absolute prohibition of all oath-taking or was specifically confronting manipulative and evasive oath practices.

Therefore, a responsible study should distinguish:

What the Greek establishes

Jesus directly addresses **swearing/oath-taking** and commands His disciples not to swear, followed by the yes/no principle.

What theology must further establish

The precise universal scope of that prohibition in every possible context.

This distinction makes the interpretation more academically credible.

33. What ὁμόσαι Does Not Mean

It is equally important to identify what ὁμόσαι does not mean.

It does not itself mean:

“to lie.”

It does not itself mean:

“to commit a crime.”

It does not itself mean:

“to make a false statement.”

It means:

“to swear / to take an oath.”

False swearing requires additional semantic and contextual considerations.

This is a crucial point for accurate Greek interpretation.

34. The Deep Theological Principle

The word study leads to a larger theological principle:

A human oath cannot give human speech the absolute character of divine faithfulness.

Human beings remain creatures.

They are limited in:

- knowledge,
- power,
- foresight,
- consistency,

- and moral perfection.

Therefore, the Christian's confidence should not rest on the sacredness of an oath formula.

It should rest upon truthfulness.

35. Jesus' Teaching in One Sentence

The central message of Matthew 5:34–37 can be summarized:

Do not depend upon oath-taking to make your speech credible; let your ordinary word be truthful.

The Greek structure supports this movement:

ὀμόσαι — to swear

→

μὴ ... ὅλως — do not ... at all

→

ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν — your word

→

ναί ... οὐ — yes ... no.

This is the heart of Jesus' teaching on Christian speech.

Conclusion

The Greek word ὀμόσαι (*omosaī*) is the central word in Jesus' statement:

ἐγὼ δὲ λέγω ὑμῖν μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“But I say to you, do not swear at all.”

Its lexical form is ὀμνύω (*omnyō*), meaning:

to swear or to take an oath.

The form **ὀμόσαι** is an **aorist active infinitive**, used with **μή** to express the prohibition:

μὴ ὀμόσαι — not to swear / do not swear.

Jesus then adds:

ὅλως — at all / altogether.

His positive alternative appears in Matthew 5:37:

ἔστω δὲ ὁ λόγος ὑμῶν ναὶ ναί, οὐ οὐ

“Let your word be ‘Yes, yes,’ ‘No, no.’”

The contrast is therefore clear:

ὀμόσαι — to swear

versus

λόγος — word/speech

and:

ναί — yes

οὐ — no.

Jesus does not teach His disciples to find a better oath formula.

He calls them toward truthful speech.

The Christian's word should not need an oath to become trustworthy.

A human oath remains a human oath. It cannot become divine merely because God's name is invoked. Human beings remain finite and fallible, while God's faithfulness is perfect.

Therefore, the central Christian principle can be expressed:

Do not make an oath necessary for truth. Let your word be truthful.

Let your yes be yes.

Let your no be no.

And at the center of Jesus' command stands the Greek expression:

μὴ ὀμόσαι ὅλως

“Do not swear at all.”